



Simputer vs the World

While the Simputer was conceptualised to serve a completely different purpose compared to the current range of handheld devices from Palm, Compaq and Psion, this comparison table highlights the differences in features and physical characteristics of the Simputer vis-a-vis other handhelds.

	Simputer	Palm m105	Compaq iPAQ H3850	Psion Series 5MX
Processor	32-bit Intel Strong-ARM SA-1110 at 206 MHz	32-bit Intel Strong-ARM SA-1110 at 206 MHz	32-bit Intel Strong-ARM SA-1110 at 206 MHz	ARM710T RISC CPU at 36 MHz
RAM	16 to 64 MB	8 MB	64 MB	16 MB
ROM	8 to 32 MB	2 MB	32 MB	8 MB
Screen resolution	240x320	160x160	240x320	640x240
Screen type	Colour/Mono-chrome LCD	Monochrome LCD	Transflective TFT, 64 K colours	16-level greyscale LCD
Dimensions	6x3.75x19 inches	4.65x3.11x0.7 inches	5.3x3.3x0.62 inches	6.7x3.5x0.9 inches
Weight	250 gm	125 gm	185 gm	355 gm
Operating system	Linux Kernel 2.4.18	Palm OS 3.5	Microsoft Pocket PC 2002	EPOC (32-bit multi-tasking)
Connectivity	USB, IrDA, Modem, Smart Card	Infrared, Serial	USB, Serial, Infrared	Serial, Infrared
Price (approx)	Rs 13,000 to 15,000	Rs 9,625	Rs 33,500	Rs 8,750

user profiles, applications and settings, so different groups with individual Smart Cards can use a single Simputer.

Forward march

The Simputer is built in the image of a personal computer and can be used in varied sectors. It can be used for e-governance where the Smart Card stores information

and updated on a regular basis. In addition, the e-mail and Internet access capabilities make it a cheap and efficient route of communication.

The frontiers that the Simputer opens are immense. Besides the obvious advantages of communication and education, traders and farmers can also find out the newest prices of goods, keep stock of their inventories, get information on bank loans and schemes, and maintain records of their harvest cycles and yields. The barter system, still practiced in some places, can be digitised and converted into a regularised format with secure transactions using the Smart Card support. With the ability to take on external storage, this device can hold additional

information such as remote healthcare assistance and information, health schedules and administration of vaccines, advice on livestock and farming practices, etc. Last but not the least, with its multimedia capabilities, it can also be used as a mobile entertainment device.

With such a vast array of applications at such ease and affordability, the Simputer, when mass produced, may just find itself in places where clean drinking water hasn't reached yet. ■

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“Poor or no use of technology in the rural market can be exploited with a certain degree of innovation”

regarding voter registration, ration distribution, survey and census data, education and even health care. For rural banking, Smart Cards can be used as digital pass-books, for synchronisation of transaction details between agents. One of the most prolific uses of this device could be in the field of education where it can be used as a mobile kiosk for teaching languages, reading and writing—and this is further extended, given its multimedia capabilities. Newer courseware and training modules can be downloaded into its memory

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